

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Hippopotamus Defense

Central restraint, adaptive breaks, king safety, and practical move-order skill

TRAINING WORKBOOK

50 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Move-Order Discipline - Stage 1



HIPPO FOUNDATION

POSITION PROMPT

Black has chosen a flexible fianchetto without yet promising a full Hippo shell.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Move-Order Discipline - Stage 2



HIPPO FOUNDATION

POSITION PROMPT

The central pawns restrain White while both black knights still have flexible routes.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Move-Order Discipline - Stage 3



HIPPO FOUNDATION

POSITION PROMPT

Black is castled before adding slow flank moves, so king safety is not borrowed from the future.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

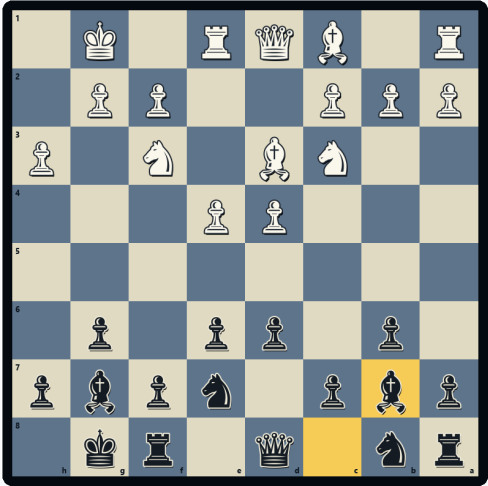
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Move-Order Discipline - Stage 4



HIPPO FOUNDATION

POSITION PROMPT

The b7-bishop has joined the pressure on e4 while White still owns more space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

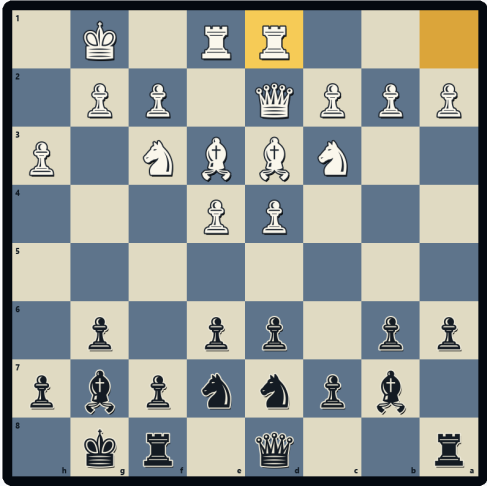
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Move-Order Discipline - Stage 5



HIPPO FOUNDATION

POSITION PROMPT

The recognizable Hippo shell is in place, and Black is already due to read White's center instead of adding a decorative waiting move.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. Rad1

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. Closed Center and Kingside Counterplay - Stage 1



HIPPO CENTER

POSITION PROMPT

Both kings are safe and White's center remains broad but fluid.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

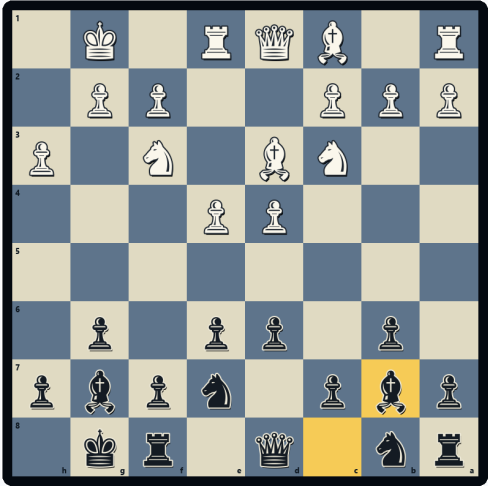
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Closed Center and Kingside Counterplay - Stage 2



HIPPO CENTER

POSITION PROMPT

Black has completed the long-diagonal battery without creating central contact.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

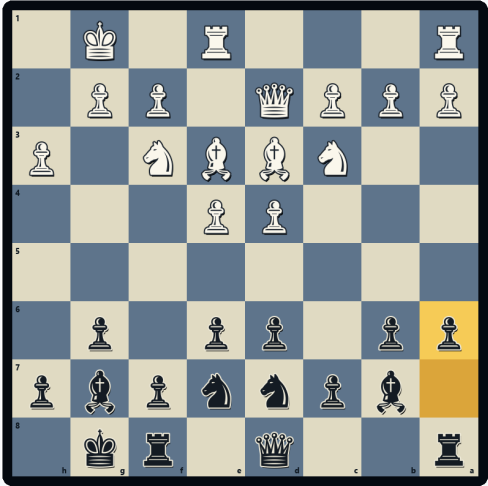
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Closed Center and Kingside Counterplay - Stage 3



HIPPO CENTER

POSITION PROMPT

The shell is ready and White must soon decide whether to close, exchange, or attack on a wing.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Closed Center and Kingside Counterplay - Stage 4



HIPPO CENTER

POSITION PROMPT

White's d5 and Black's ...e5 have locked the center, making wing operations more realistic.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. d5 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Closed Center and Kingside Counterplay - Stage 5



HIPPO CENTER

POSITION PROMPT

The ...f5 contact has opened the g-file structure and changed the position from maneuvering to calculation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. d5 e5 12. Nh2 f5 13. exf5 gxf5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Choosing ...e5 or ...d5 - Stage 1



HIPPO CENTRAL BREAKS

POSITION PROMPT

Black has played ...e5 while White can still choose tension, exchange, or d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Choosing ...e5 or ...d5 - Stage 2



HIPPO CENTRAL BREAKS

POSITION PROMPT

White has closed with d5, fixing an e5-d6 chain and defining future wing play.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 e5 11. d5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Choosing ...e5 or ...d5 - Stage 3



HIPPO CENTRAL BREAKS

POSITION PROMPT

The direct ...d5 break challenges e4 before White begins a slow attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 d5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Choosing ...e5 or ...d5 - Stage 4



HIPPO CENTRAL BREAKS

POSITION PROMPT

Central exchanges have opened the e-file and given Black active piece squares instead of a cramped shell.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 d5 11. exd5 exd5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

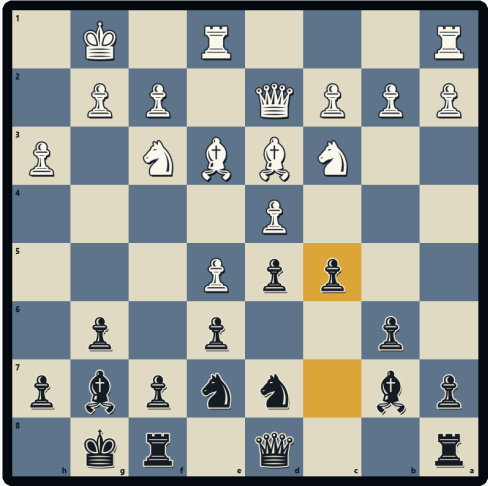
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Choosing ...e5 or ...d5 - Stage 5



HIPPO CENTRAL BREAKS

POSITION PROMPT

White has answered ...d5 with e5, and Black immediately attacks d4 with ...c5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 d5 11. e5 c5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

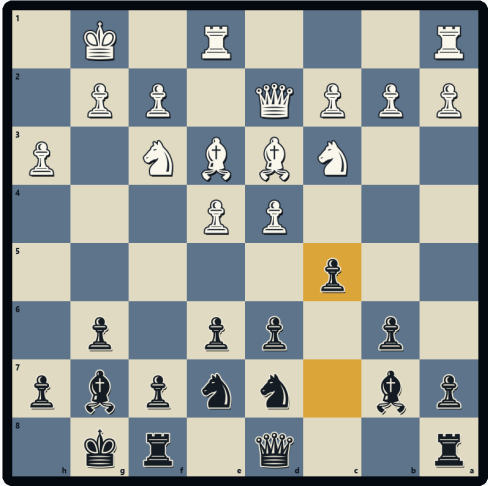
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Queenside Breaks with ...c5 and ...b5 - Stage 1



HIPPO QUEENSIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

The ...c5 break attacks d4 and asks whether White's center can remain broad.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 c5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Queenside Breaks with ...c5 and ...b5 - Stage 2



HIPPO QUEENSIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

White has closed d5 and Black has fixed the center with ...e5, making flank play more concrete.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 c5 11. d5 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Queenside Breaks with ...c5 and ...b5 - Stage 3



HIPPO QUEENSIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

White's h-pawn has reached h5, and ...h6 forces White to define the kingside tension before Black commits the king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. h4 Bb7 9. h5 h6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

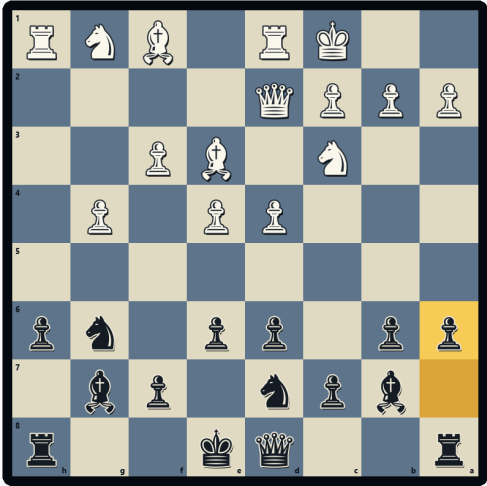
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Queenside Breaks with ...c5 and ...b5 - Stage 4



HIPPO QUEENSIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Black has recaptured on g6 with the e7-knight and prepares queenside expansion while White's g-pawn advances.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. h4 Bb7 9. h5 h6 10. hxg6 Nxg6 11. g4 a6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

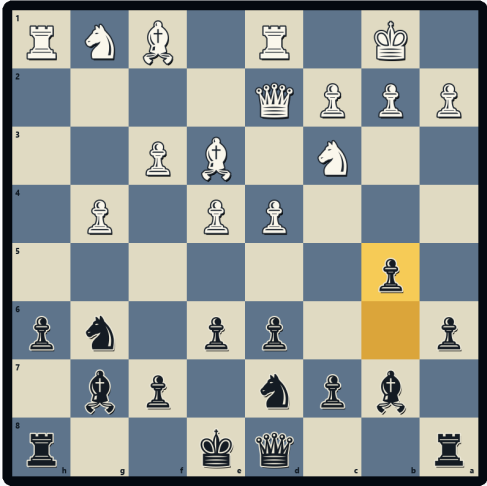
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Queenside Breaks with ...c5 and ...b5 - Stage 5



HIPPO QUEENSIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Black's ...b5 attacks the wing containing White's king instead of defending passively on the kingside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. h4 Bb7 9. h5 h6 10. hxg6 Nxg6 11. g4 a6 12. Kb1 b5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

21. The ...f5 Break - Stage 1



HIPPO KING-SIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

The center is closed and Black can consider a kingside break without immediately opening the king in the middle.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. d5 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

22. The ...f5 Break - Stage 2



HIPPO KING-SIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

The f3-knight has stepped away, and Black must decide whether the closed center already permits immediate ...f5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. d5 e5 12. Nh2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

23. The ...f5 Break - Stage 3



HIPPO KING-SIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Black has created ...f5 contact without spending another tempo on a decorative waiting move.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. d5 e5 12. Nh2 f5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

24. The ...f5 Break - Stage 4



HIPPO KING-SIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

The g-pawn recapture has opened the g-file and placed a pawn on f5 that may support further space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. d5 e5 12. Nh2 f5 13. exf5 gxf5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

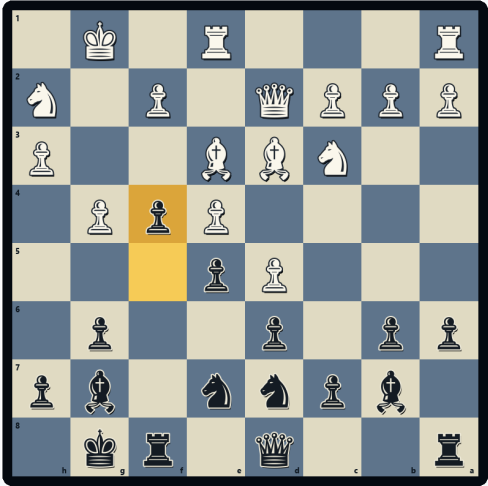
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

25. The ...f5 Break - Stage 5



HIPPO KING-SIDE PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

Black has advanced to f4, gaining space but also fixing a target that must be supported by pieces.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 a6 11. d5 e5 12. Nh2 f5 13. g4 f4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

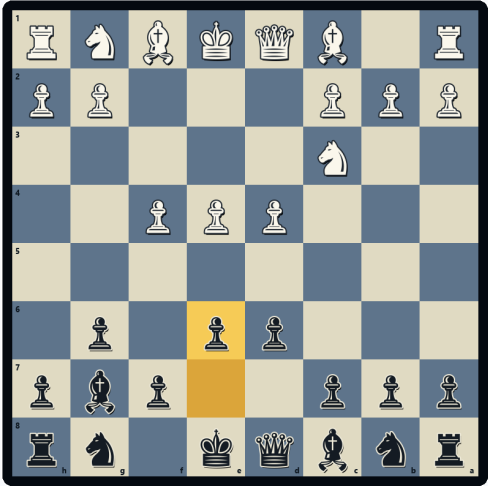
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

26. Meeting White's f-Pawn Expansion - Stage 1



HIPPO VS F4

POSITION PROMPT

White has claimed extra kingside and central space with f4 before completing development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

27. Meeting White's f-Pawn Expansion - Stage 2



HIPPO VS F4

POSITION PROMPT

Both sides develop behind the tension while White retains the threat of f5 or e5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 b6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

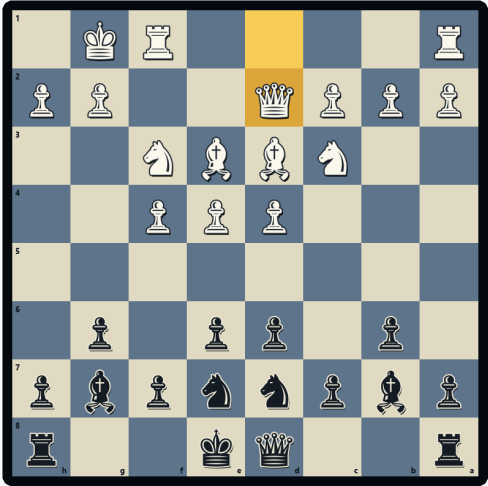
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

28. Meeting White's f-Pawn Expansion - Stage 3



HIPPO VS F4

POSITION PROMPT

White's pieces now support a direct f5 advance, so Black's quiet shell must become concrete.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 b6 7. O-O Bb7 8. Be3 Nd7 9. Qd2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

29. Meeting White's f-Pawn Expansion - Stage 4



HIPPO VS F4

POSITION PROMPT

The position has reached maximum tension before White's thematic f5 break.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 b6 7. O-O Bb7 8. Be3 Nd7 9. Qd2 a6 10. Rae1 h6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

30. Meeting White's f-Pawn Expansion - Stage 5



HIPPO VS F4

POSITION PROMPT

Black has exchanged the f5 spearhead and used the g-pawn to recapture, changing files and dark-square control.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 b6 7. O-O Bb7 8. Be3 Nd7 9. Qd2 a6 10. Rae1 h6 11. f5 exf5 12. exf5 gxf5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

31. Surviving the h- and g-Pawn Storm - Stage 1



HIPPO KING SAFETY

POSITION PROMPT

White has castled long and placed the f3 pawn behind a direct kingside expansion.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

32. Surviving the h- and g-Pawn Storm - Stage 2



HIPPO KING SAFETY

POSITION PROMPT

Black meets h4 with ...h6, forcing White to reveal whether the attack will close or exchange the kingside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. h4 h6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

33. Surviving the h- and g-Pawn Storm - Stage 3



HIPPO KING SAFETY

POSITION PROMPT

After h5, ...g5 closes the file and asks whether White can justify further pawn moves.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. h4 h6 9. h5 g5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

34. Surviving the h- and g-Pawn Storm - Stage 4



HIPPO KING SAFETY

POSITION PROMPT

White has played f4 and Black gains space with ...g4, but the advanced chain now requires tactical support.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. h4 h6 9. h5 g5 10. f4 g4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

35. Surviving the h- and g-Pawn Storm - Stage 5



HIPPO KING SAFETY

POSITION PROMPT

Black strikes with ...d5 after White spends another tempo developing behind the pawn storm.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. f3 b6 8. h4 h6 9. h5 g5 10. f4 g4 11. Nge2 d5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

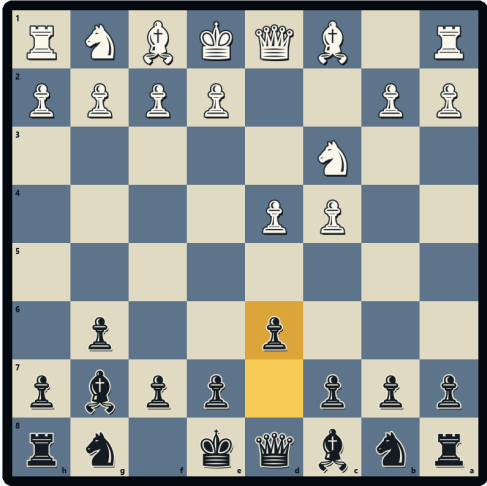
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

36. Against 1.d4 and 1.c4 Centers - Stage 1



HIPPO VS QUEEN PAWNS

POSITION PROMPT

White has claimed d4 and c4 while Black begins from the same flexible fianchetto idea.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

37. Against 1.d4 and 1.c4 Centers - Stage 2



HIPPO VS QUEEN PAWNS

POSITION PROMPT

White owns a three-pawn center and Black has developed without challenging it yet.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

38. Against 1.d4 and 1.c4 Centers - Stage 3



HIPPO VS QUEEN PAWNS

POSITION PROMPT

Both bishops oppose the center from long diagonals, but White still has more room.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 b6 7. O-O Bb7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

39. Against 1.d4 and 1.c4 Centers - Stage 4



HIPPO VS QUEEN PAWNS

POSITION PROMPT

Black is fully developed enough to choose a break rather than add more waiting moves.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 b6 7. O-O Bb7 8. Re1 Nd7 9. Bf4 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

40. Against 1.d4 and 1.c4 Centers - Stage 5



HIPPO VS QUEEN PAWNS

POSITION PROMPT

The center has closed with d5 and ...e5, creating a structure closer to a King's Indian than a quiet shell.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 b6 7. O-O Bb7 8. Re1 Nd7 9. Bf4 O-O 10. d5 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

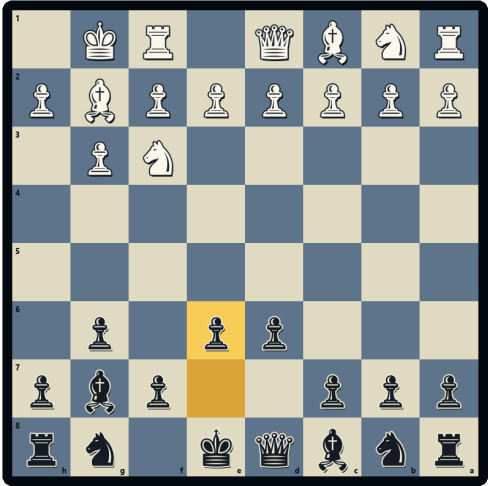
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

41. When White Refuses a Big Center - Stage 1



HIPPO ADAPTATION

POSITION PROMPT

White has chosen a quiet Reti shell and left the center available.

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 g6 2. g3 Bg7 3. Bg2 d6 4. O-O e6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

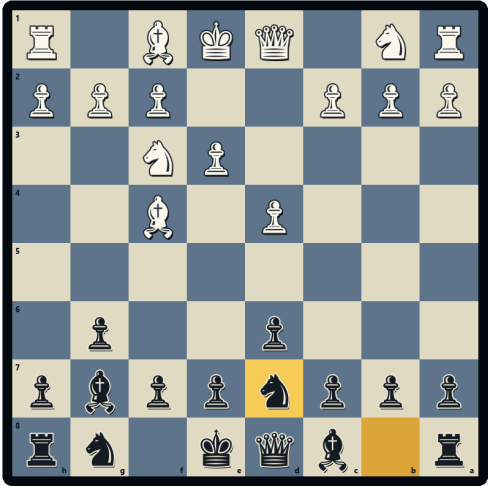
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

42. When White Refuses a Big Center - Stage 2



HIPPO ADAPTATION

POSITION PROMPT

White's London development does not justify Black surrendering the whole center without question.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Bf4 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Nf3 Nd7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

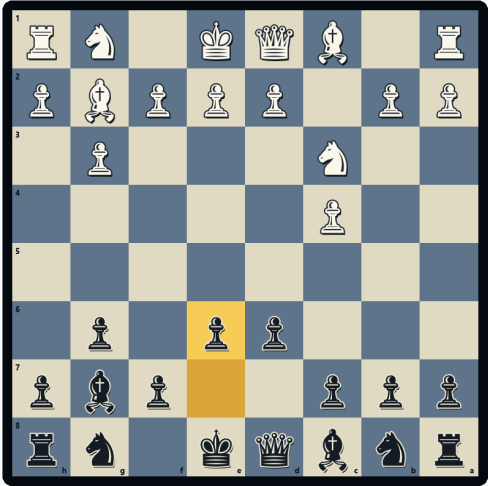
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

43. When White Refuses a Big Center - Stage 3



HIPPO ADAPTATION

POSITION PROMPT

The English move order creates queenside influence without an immediate e4-d4 pawn duo.

REFERENCE LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

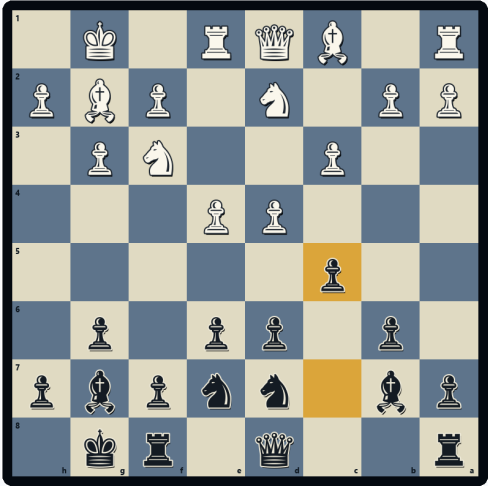
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

44. When White Refuses a Big Center - Stage 4



HIPPO ADAPTATION

POSITION PROMPT

When White finally plays d4, Black answers with ...c5 instead of completing unnecessary waiting moves.

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 g6 2. g3 Bg7 3. Bg2 d6 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. Nbd2 Nd7 7. e4 b6 8. c3 Bb7 9. Re1 O-O 10. d4 c5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

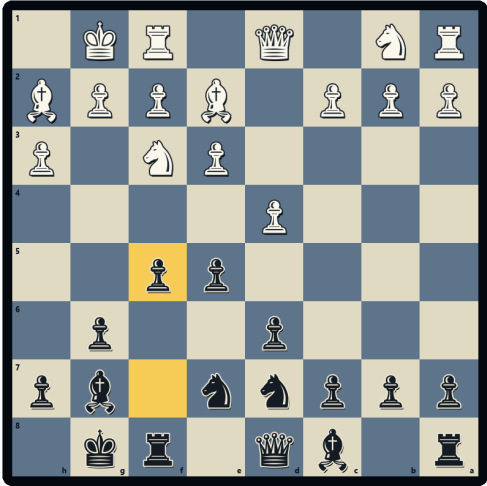
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

45. When White Refuses a Big Center - Stage 5



HIPPO ADAPTATION

POSITION PROMPT

Black has used ...e5 and ...f5 to claim space because White's restrained center allowed direct occupation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Bf4 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Nf3 Nd7 5. h3 e5 6. Bh2 Ne7 7. Be2 O-O 8. O-O f5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

46. Tactics, Exchanges, and Transformation - Stage 1



HIPPO PRACTICAL PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

White has exchanged the dark bishops and forced Black's king to recapture on g7, changing the usual attacking geometry.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O Nd7 7. Bh6 O-O 8. Bxg7 Kxg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

47. Tactics, Exchanges, and Transformation - Stage 2



HIPPO PRACTICAL PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

The ...d5 break has produced an open e-file and a position that must be judged as ordinary central chess.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 d5 11. exd5 exd5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

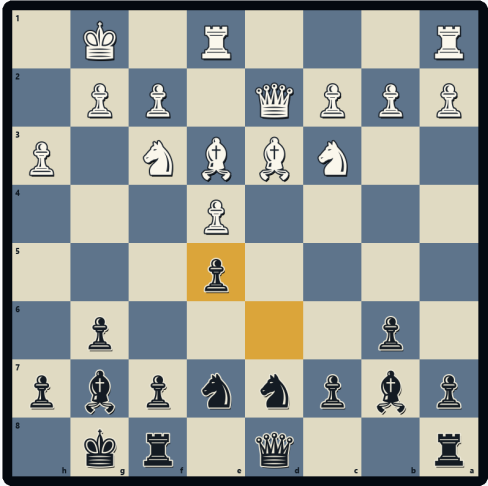
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

48. Tactics, Exchanges, and Transformation - Stage 3



HIPPO PRACTICAL PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

The ...e5 contact has been exchanged, opening lines and removing the original closed-center story.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 e5 11. dxe5 dxe5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

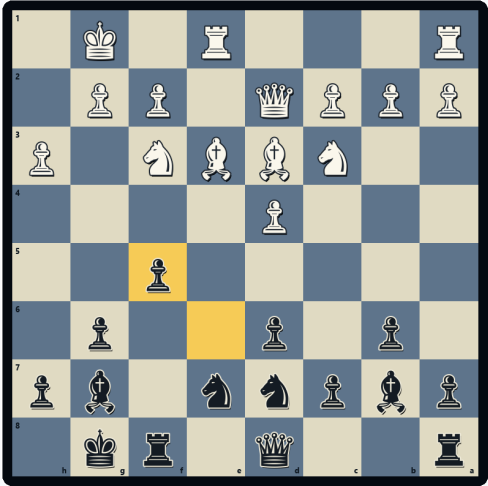
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

49. Tactics, Exchanges, and Transformation - Stage 4



HIPPO PRACTICAL PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

An early ...f5 has opened the center before it was fully closed, exposing why break timing matters.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 f5 11. exf5 exf5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

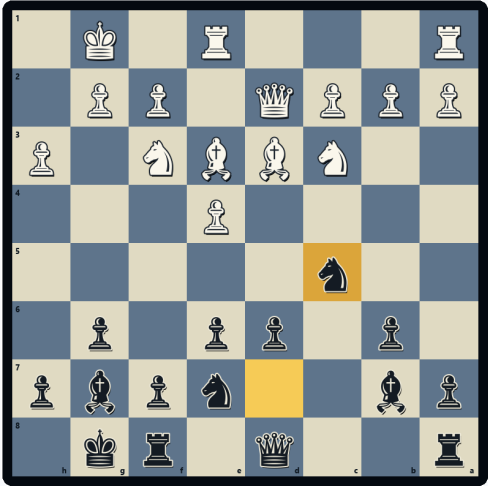
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

50. Tactics, Exchanges, and Transformation - Stage 5



HIPPO PRACTICAL PLAY

POSITION PROMPT

The ...c5 exchange has activated Black's d7-knight and reduced White's central space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 b6 8. h3 Bb7 9. Be3 Nd7 10. Qd2 c5 11. dxc5 Nxc5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.